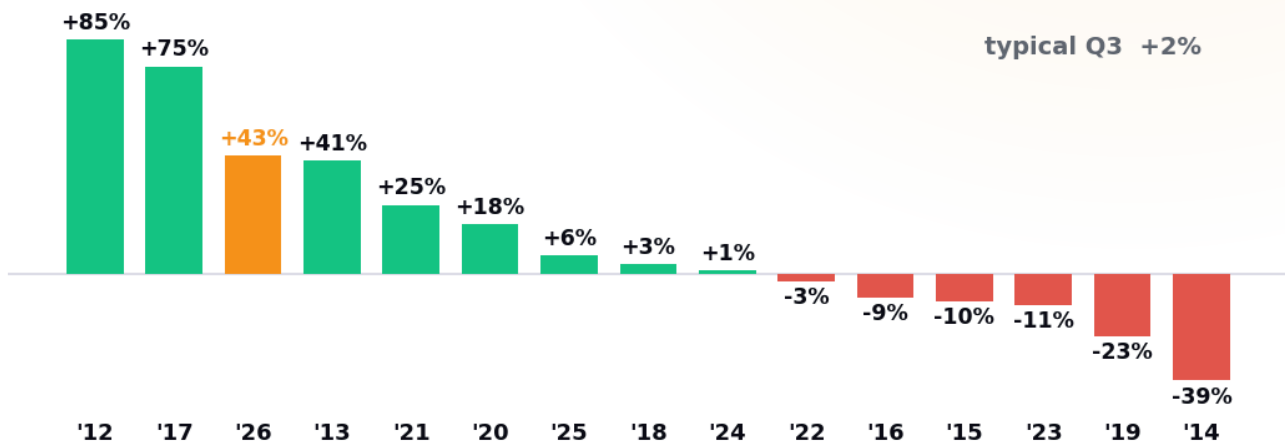


THE QUARTER STUDY

Bitcoin just closed one of its best Q3s ever, +43% from the July 1 open. The typical Q3 is +2%. So I checked every quarter since late 2011, 60 of them.

Every Q3 ranked, what followed every +30% quarter, bull years against bear years, the best quarter before and after each bear's final low, and 2014 against 2015 side by side.



every Bitcoin Q3 since 2012, open Jul 1 to close Sep 30. 2026 closed Sep 30.

+43%

Q3 2026, open to close, 3rd best of 15

20 of 20

big quarters followed by a 20% drop from the high

+41%

the only bear quarter this big before its final low, 2014

Educational, not financial advice. Every percentage in this guide says what it is measured from. Quarter returns run from the first open to the last close of the calendar quarter.



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THE RANKING

EVERY Q3, RANKED

QUARTER	OPEN	CLOSE	Q3 RETURN	Q4 AFTER	YEAR
Q3 2012	\$6.60	\$12.22	+85%	+8%	bull
Q3 2017	\$2,465	\$4,326	+75%	+221%	bull
Q3 2026	\$58,527	\$83,563	+43%	open	bear
Q3 2013	\$89.41	\$126	+41%	+480%	bull
Q3 2021	\$35,060	\$43,834	+25%	+5%	bull
Q3 2020	\$9,137	\$10,778	+18%	+169%	bull
Q3 2025	\$107,164	\$114,065	+6%	-23%	bull
Q3 2018	\$6,386	\$6,598	+3%	-44%	bear
Q3 2024	\$62,676	\$63,302	+1%	+47%	bull
Q3 2022	\$19,961	\$19,425	-3%	-15%	bear
Q3 2016	\$666	\$608	-9%	+59%	bull
Q3 2015	\$263	\$236	-10%	+83%	bear
Q3 2023	\$30,469	\$26,966	-11%	+57%	bull
Q3 2019	\$10,759	\$8,298	-23%	-14%	bull
Q3 2014	\$640	\$391	-39%	-18%	bear

Bitstamp BTC/USD daily. Return = first open to last close. Bull and bear years use the same calendar lists as every September study (bear 2014, 2015, 2018, 2022, 2026).

Only 2012 and 2017 had a bigger Q3, and both were bull years. This is the best Q3 in 9 years and the first one this big in a bear year.

THE SEASON

IS Q3 USUALLY WEAK?

QUARTER	COUNT	TYPICAL RETURN	GREEN
Q1	15	-2%	7 of 15
Q2	15	+8%	9 of 15
Q3	14	+2%	8 of 14
Q4	15	+8%	9 of 15

Every calendar quarter from Q4 2011, Q3s through 2025. Typical = median, open to close.

Q3 is the second-weakest quarter by median, ahead only of Q1, and green a little more than half the time. None of the four quarters is reliable enough to trade on its own. The gap between the best and worst of any quarter is hundreds of percent, so the calendar is context, not a signal.

AFTER BIG QUARTERS

WHAT CAME AFTER **+30%**

Since 2012 Bitcoin had 20 quarters of +30% or more. The next quarter was green 10 of 20 times. The last column is the biggest drop inside the next quarter, measured from the high (including the big quarter's own high) to the lowest wick after it.

BIG QUARTER	GAIN	YEAR	NEXT QUARTER	BIGGEST DROP FROM THE HIGH
Q2 2012	+35%	bull	+85%	-57%
Q3 2012	+85%	bull	+8%	-42%
Q1 2013	+626%	bull	-6%	-83%
Q3 2013	+41%	bull	+480%	-67%
Q4 2013	+480%	bull	-38%	-66%
Q2 2014	+41%	bear	-39%	-47%
Q4 2015	+83%	bear	-4%	-30%
Q2 2016	+61%	bull	-9%	-40%
Q4 2016	+59%	bull	+11%	-34%
Q2 2017	+130%	bull	+75%	-40%

AFTER BIG QUARTERS

EVERY ONE HAD A 20% DROP

BIG QUARTER	GAIN	YEAR	NEXT QUARTER	BIGGEST DROP FROM THE HIGH
Q3 2017	+75%	bull	+221%	-43%
Q4 2017	+221%	bull	-50%	-70%
Q2 2019	+163%	bull	-23%	-44%
Q2 2020	+42%	bull	+18%	-21%
Q4 2020	+169%	bull	+103%	-31%
Q1 2021	+103%	bull	-40%	-56%
Q1 2023	+72%	bull	+7%	-20%
Q4 2023	+57%	bull	+69%	-22%
Q1 2024	+69%	bull	-12%	-23%
Q4 2024	+47%	bull	-12%	-30%

Drops on intraday wicks. Next quarter = its own open to close.

20 OF 20

All 20 fell 20% or more from the high inside the next quarter. The smallest was -20% (after Q1 2023), the typical one -41%, the biggest -83% (after Q1 2013). Even the next quarters that finished green had one. Q4 2017 ran +221% with a -43% drop inside it.

BULL AGAINST BEAR

THE YEAR DECIDES IT

AFTER A +30% QUARTER	COUNT	NEXT QUARTER GREEN	TYPICAL NEXT QUARTER
Every year	20	10 of 20	+2%
Bull years	18	10 of 18	+8%
Bear years	2	0 of 2	-21%

Typical = median, open to close. The bear row is two quarters, far too few for a rule.

Bull years. The three Q3s this big, 2012, 2013 and 2017, were all followed by a green Q4, +8%, +480% and +221%. All three were bull years.

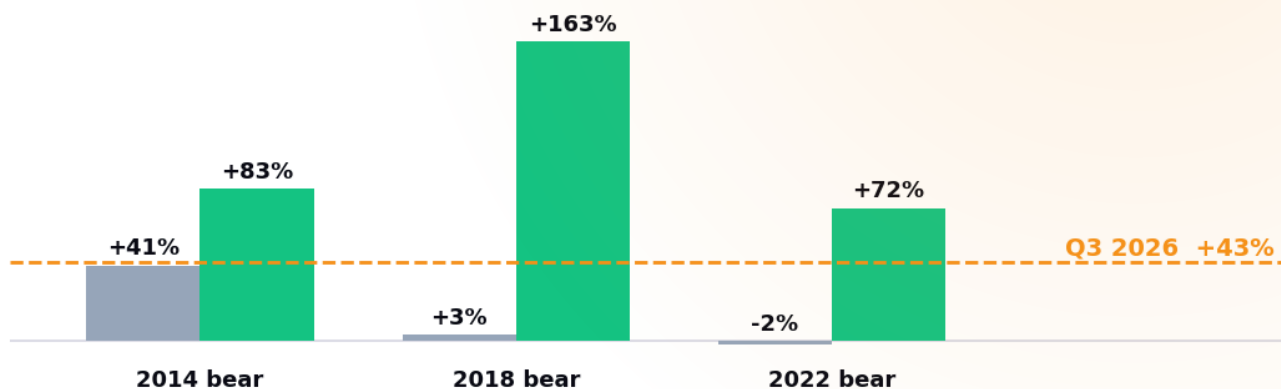
Bear years. Only two bear-year quarters ever reached +30%. Q2 2014 gained 41%, then Q3 2014 fell 39% and Bitcoin made new lows into January 2015. Q4 2015 gained 83%, but it came after the bear's final low, and Q1 2016 held at -4%.

BEFORE AND AFTER THE LOW

BEARS ALMOST NEVER DO THIS

best quarter BEFORE the final low

best quarter in the year AFTER the low



calendar quarters, open to close. Bear = from the cycle top to the final low.

BEAR	BEST QUARTER BEFORE THE FINAL LOW	BEST QUARTER IN THE YEAR AFTER
2014	Q2 2014, +41%	Q4 2015, +83%
2018	Q3 2018, +3%	Q2 2019, +163%
2022	Q1 2022, -2%	Q1 2023, +72%
2026	Q3 2026, +43%	?

Bear = from the cycle top to the final low. Quarters counted if they start inside that window.

2026 is a bear year, and no bear ever had a quarter this big before its final low. The only close one was 2014. Every final low, on the other hand, was followed within a year by a quarter of +72% to +163%.

SIDE BY SIDE

2014 AGAINST 2015

	Q2 2014	Q4 2015
Gain, open to close	+41%	+83%
Where in the cycle	inside the bear, before the final low	after the final low of January 2015
Next quarter, open to close	-39%	-4%
Biggest drop from the high, next quarter	-47%	-30%
New bear lows after	yes, into January 2015	no

If 2026 is like 2014, Q4 falls hard. A 39% quarter like Q3 2014, from Q3 2026's close of \$83,563, would end near \$51,057, a new low under \$57,735.

If 2026 is like 2015, the July 1 low of \$57,735 was the final low, and Q3 2026 was the first big quarter of the next cycle.

Q 4 2 0 2 6

THE LEVELS TO WATCH

LEVEL	WHAT IT IS
\$87,374	the Q3 high, 21 September
\$83,563	the Q3 close
\$69,700	the smallest next-quarter drop on record, -20% from the \$87,374 high
\$57,735	the July 1 wick low, the line between the two paths
\$51,057	where a 2014-style -39% quarter from the Q3 close would end

A pullback in Q4 would not settle anything. Every big quarter was followed by one. A close under \$57,735 would put 2026 on the 2014 path. Holding above it keeps the 2015 path open.

The limits. 60 quarters sounds like a lot, but big quarters are 20 of them and bear-year big quarters are 2. The bull and bear year lists are calendar labels decided in hindsight. Early years ran on a thin market with flash wicks. Treat every row here as a base rate, not a forecast.

Data pinned 30 September 2026. Bitstamp BTC/USD daily bars. Scripts: Quarters/q_study.py, Quarters/q_charts.py. This is education, not financial advice.

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